Q+A

A TALE WELL TOLD

High on accolades from the Sundance Film Festival, **Ali Fazal** says the win will help tell new stories for a global audience



Q. What kind of storytelling can we see from Richa and you after the big Sundance win for your debut production, *Girls Will Be Girls*?
We won the audience award and the special jury award for the lead actor Preeti Panigrahi at Sundance. I am absolutely ecstatic that the movie has given the world a phenomenal director in Shuchi Talathi and opened up exciting futures for Preeti and Kesav, who have debuted with *Girls Will Be Girls*. Winning the audience award has cemented our belief in the power of good screenplays.

Q. Have you contemplated leaving Bollywood for Hollywood?
I am a citizen of the free world and my craft has its own dervish destiny. I do not know where I will be physically, but this is my home and Indian cinema is my first love. *Mujhe yahaan ki kahaaniyan wahaan pahunchaani hain* [I want to take stories from here to a western audience].

Q. Have you been pushed enough as an actor?
There have been one or two occasions where I have felt pushed. Vishal Bhardwaj and Stephen Frears managed to do that to me. And in some parts of *Mirzapur* maybe. I hope for days where directors challenge me. Those are the best days spent on set.

Q. Do you feel intimidated when acting with stars like Judi Dench and Gerard Butler?
The moment the camera goes on, they are all like my buddies in a system where we are trying to tell a story through each other. It only works if we have fun while doing it. I am definitely in awe of these wonderful people, but there's so much to learn from them that I don't give much thought to intimidation.

–with Shashi Sunny

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**